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Laughing Like Heathens

When people ask her she says of course, of course, of course I do…he *loves* me, after all, he *told* me so…[though she wonders at the reliability of love told, thinking love is more like air, something we know by its presence or absence, the latter of which causes an increasingly problematic onset of symptoms that ultimately lead to death…but then bad air can kill you, too, and anyway, she has been assured that love is more like a headline than air, and thus, could most certainly be told, preferably above the fold]…shows me respect, does the right things, the right things, the things every girl dreams of [*don't* they?]…you know…flowers, candy, the unexpected card or email…[so yes, he fucks like a pile driver and squeezes nipples like he's squashing bugs but] so *of friggin course* I love him…who wouldn't?...that is to say, how could I *not*?

It's like her grandmother redux and all over again, the grandmother who came from one frigid clime to another dreaming of thaw, who ended up facing an arranged marriage out there on the sadomasochistic plains of South Dakota…who had figured it out, just in time (3), just in time (2), just in time (1) to run before getting saddled by that fat *pioneer* whose benefice was the amount of land he owned, the number of cattle he penned, the number of swine he bred and let's not forget his pious contributions to the city on the hill, that *pioneer* who wanted to set fire to her grasslands and rive her soil…[and though she ran it was like a dream, for like Dorothy from a nearby and similarly red, bible-thumping state, the grandmother awoke one day to all of that and more, and this, without even clicking her heals]

Her grandmother made it to Kansas City, though exactly how, no one ever really found out, but

god*damn* were the stories good…[that her name would be instantly recognized in the riverfront district—near where the Missouri and Kansas rivers met like spreading legs—for years afterward, shows that the best stories are never told, only hinted at]…the family, struggling to avoid scandal, issued an edict stating she had become confused over there being two Kansas Citys, that is, one city in two states, and that she had instinctively gone to the river seeking baptism and renewal [*If the blind lead the blind, both shall fall into the ditch*.--Matthew 15:14, more or less]…ministers, sinisters, clerics, cholerics, reverends, reprehends, rabbis, rabbits, rectors, rectals all got involved, got her cleaned up, force fed her newtestament soup and adorned her with a latent-but-too-late chastity belt, and then they shipped her back to South Dakota on a cattle car [but first to the bughouse, and this was the one thing in her life she would never talk about…she would call these her dark years, though she remained only weeks]

Some say that's where the granddaughter got it, meaning from her grandmother, though it was never intended [she hates this word, because she is one] as a compliment but rather as sad commentary, an indictment of the grandmother, still considered an impious rebel [all the granddaughter hears is *revel*], a woman the family felt would have been taught a thing or two in the Inquisition…but lacking a rack [she had a rack, to be sure, a fantastical pair she proudly called her double-odds, but alas, they wanted her *on* one] they warned the granddaughter ad nauseam not to be like the grandmother, who was [check all that apply] 1 crazy 2 half-baked 3 softheaded 4 dotty 5 affected 6 daft 7 non compos mentis 8 rabid…after all, consider her actions…to wit, setting her husband's cattle, chickens and swine free, sending them scattering over the plains during a torrid summer storm…and the old coot, standing out in the rain, giggling like a lunatic, soiling her panties and the family name all in one squirt…[this, too, became

legend, like the trip to KC…locals to this day know the story of the Madwoman of Minnehaha County, whose silhouette would imprint on their eyes that night each time the lightning struck, backlighting her, her with arms out, running around as if possessed and speaking in tongues, rather like a rave we might say, and crowds, more women than men, gathered roadside just to watch, and let's face it, to vicariously join in]

Her grandmother is the only one in the family the girl sees as sane, *because* she chewed tobacco, *because* she kept a bottle of elixir hidden in the cracks of the milking parlor walls, *because* she said masturbation was the only proof she had ever found of God ["God wouldn't add a button unless he meant it to be pushed" (sic)]…this in direct opposition to the rest of the puri[sa]tans in the family, so prim and proper, buttoned up righter and tighter than a Lutheran's shirt collar…but the quickest way to fuck with a child's head is to take the very thing or person the child admires and condemn it to the ninth circle of Hell…so we don't need Freud to understand why the granddaughter dreamed of freeing things, of freeing things, of freeing any things held against their better instincts, whether animal or human, dreamed of filling the plains with them, the formerly cooped (in or up), enclosed, fenced (in), immured, mewed (up), penned, shut in, walled (in or up)

So the granddaughter ran, too [she didn't know she was running at first…daydreaming, she missed the farm driveway and somehow just kept on driving, through the rain, through the stop light, through the tears, through the night, through the throw up (nerves), through the by and by, lord, the by and by]…to Kansas City, of course, an homage [a tribute to the one woman in the family who had bared her tits in public, who had pulled up her skirt and would have shown it all

if not roped and tackled by a visiting rodeo rider [and none of them knew, none of them knew except the granddaughter, who was told these stories one stormy night over two bottles of cheap red wine, none of them knew that she'd let that rodeo rider rope and tackle her again later that night…she would say about that night, all those years later—this a parable clearly intended for the intended—that one night of blissful lust trumps a thousand nights of passive receiving]]…and once in KC the granddaughter walked right up between the legs of the Kansas and Missouri confluence…she touched the dampness before wading in to baptize herself, born again into the itsokaytobewhoyouare faith [not yet eligible for exemption from Federal income tax under IRC Section 501(c)(3) and frankly may never be due to the dwindling membership]

When the minister sent by the family found the granddaughter in KC [and oh, how she had hoped he would be her rodeo rider, but times change and he was instead a pathetic and muculent man], he wanted to know all of her secrets, in detail, with photos if possible [nothing lecherous about it, you understand…he simply needed to know how far she'd fallen]…she told him about her grandmother instead, hoping to liberate them both, but he just kept saying they could do this the easy way or the hard way, it was up to her…and if she had detailed lurid stories of lesbian affairs the best thing she could do was come out with them now, just spread it all out right there on the coffeehouse table

When she returned to Minnehaha County there was nothing haha about it…they were all there, waiting …not just her parents and siblings, but relatives, some alive, some exhumed and looking on from open coffins, some just ash in urns, some daguerreotypes, all equal in austerity, everyone except the one woman the granddaughter *wanted* there…each in turn told her their

memories of her, as if this was some kind of memorial [*hey, I'm right here*], some kind of living obituary [*hey, I'm right friggin here*], some kind of intervention [*hey*]….and when she dared mention her grandmother they told her it was just that kind of thinking that had messed her up…no, they agreed, she would apologize to the former fiancé from whom she had run, patch things up, and the wedding would be rescheduled [god help us may she still be a virgin] not only for her good but for the good of her family….her, so lucky to have a guy like that…her, so lucky to have a guy willing to wait, to stand by her tomfoolery….her, so lucky

She cried on the wedding night [how could she *not*?]…1st when he pillaged her 2nd when he pillaged her 3rd 4th 5th when he pillaged her and finally 6th when a story came on the news about a young woman's body found in a shallow creek in Kansas, a sofarnameless woman identified only as possibly being "a missing porn star", as if *that* was her identity…and once he realized the tears weren't for him and his vagina-wall-tearing tenacity, weren't for him and his penis-pumped manhood, weren't for him but for some slut on the tv news who had spread her legs to the world and was now dead…wellsir, he asked her—no, let's be accurate…he accused her—how could she cry for some girl she never knew [and isn't it always special when the obligatory wedding fuck is hardly over and the patriarchy begins?]…her answer, such as it was, made no sense to him, for she simply said she could relate to that girl somehow

…whatthefuckdoyoumeanbythatnonsense? he asked…she shook her head and said come on, just enjoy your wedding night, and that brought him around, never mind she had said *your* not *our*, never mind her tone bit like a bitch named January, never mind she had already moved past him…because really, how could she tell him, now that the receiving had begun? how could she tell him that she had the genetic curse^promise? of her grandmother [see 1 crazy 2 half-baked, *et al*]

…how could she tell him that already she was planning to leave his ass and all the bling that came with him…how, how, and how could she tell him that she had gone to the middle of a field in Minnehaha County at night with her grandmother, drunk on red wine, the two of them dancing and raising their arms to the bawdy and lascivious summer storm, laughing like heathens?